The Early Alphabetic Inscriptions Found by the Shrine of Hathor at Serabit el-Khadem

Author(s): Orly Goldwasser

Source: *Israel Exploration Journal*, 2022, Vol. 72, No. 1 (2022), pp. 14-48

Published by: Israel Exploration Society

Stable URL: https://www.jstor.org/stable/10.2307/27196180

# The Early Alphabetic Inscriptions Found by the Shrine of Hathor at Serabit el-Khadem: Palaeography, Materiality, and Agency

Orly Goldwasser
The Hebrew University of Jerusalem

**ABSTRACT:** Only four Proto-Sinaitic alphabetic inscriptions, all on small portable objects, were found in the temple precinct in Serabit el-Khadem, all by the shrine of Hathor. Most of the other (around 30) Proto-Sinaitic inscriptions are rock graffiti found inside and around the mines. In the first part of the article, I present the four finds bearing the alphabetic inscriptions, offering a detailed palaeographic analysis of each inscription. The second part of the article considers the objects themselves, their forms, and their possible cultural role in the world of their users.

## INTRODUCTION

The Egyptian temple precinct at Serabit el-Khadem yielded four Proto-Sinaitic alphabetic inscriptions, all on small portable objects. All the other Proto-Sinaitic inscriptions (around 30) are rock graffiti found inside and around the mines, at their entrances, and on the road to the temple mound. Thirteen inscriptions were found at the entrance to Mine L and inside it, five were discovered in Mine M (an extension of Mine L); a few others were found in the vicinity of other mines.[1] The longest alphabetic inscriptions, presumably produced by scribes of greater skill, were found in Mines L and M. Based on this evidence, I have suggested that the Semitic alphabet may have been invented by illiterate Canaanite workers associated with these particular mines (Goldwasser 2012).[2]

The four small objects that form the topic of this article were found by Petrie around the holiest part of the Egyptian temple: the shrine of Hathor. They all bear

* I am grateful to Marsha Hill, Irit Ziffer, Benjamin Sass, and Niv Allon for their remarks. All mistakes are, of course, mine alone. My thanks are extended to Halely Harel for her help with the production of the images and pictures.

1 See table in Sass 1988: 10; Goldwasser 2012: 9–10, n. 8.

2 Sanders (2009) is close in his approach to the invention and dissemination of the alphabet to my views. My illiteracy hypothesis is now further supported by Steiner's (2016: 332) conclusion that the producers of the inscriptions in Serabit el-Khadem were 'untrammelled by any consistent, official orthography based on underlying, morpho-phonemic structure or even on slow, careful speech'; see also, recently, Lehmann 2021.

alphabetic inscriptions and are of modest size. The most famous of the four — the miniature sphinx — is the ‘Rosetta Stone’ of the alphabet; it bears the bilingual inscription that enabled Gardiner to decipher the early alphabetic script in 1916. The second, a block statue, bears the inscription *Nʿm rb nqbn* (‘*Nʿm*, chief miner’). The third object is a tiny bust statuette bearing the word *tnt* (‘gift’?). The fourth is a similar, but weathered and broken, statuette, on which only two letters have been preserved: *lb*[…] (see discussion below).

It is noteworthy that the inscriptions on these four small items were the only alphabetic inscriptions found in the entire temple precinct. No other alphabetic inscription — not a single graffito or letter — was found on the Egyptian stelae or any other Egyptian architectural remains in the temple area. This is significant since it may suggest that the producers of the alphabetic inscriptions in Serabit were active during a limited period when the Egyptian administration controlled access to the temple precinct.[3] For example, Pinch (1993: 337) remarks that visitors were entering and writing graffiti inside the temple when the Deir el-Bahri temple was in decline. If the producers of the alphabet had been active, for example, during the Hyksos period, they would probably have left at least some alphabetic graffiti within the temple precinct. This fact is in line with my contention that the alphabet was invented during Amenemhet III’s reign and not later, during the Second Intermediate Period (cf. Lemaire 2008). During this period, the area was more or less abandoned by the official Egyptian administration and access to the temple area should not have been restricted.[4]

In the first part of the article, I present the four finds bearing the alphabetic inscriptions. For each object, I offer a detailed palaeographic analysis of its inscriptions. The second part of the article follows the objects themselves, their archaeological context, their forms, and their possible cultural role in the world of their Canaanite users.

## THE PALAEOGRAPHY OF THE INSCRIPTIONS ON THE FOUR STATUETTES

The block statue (fig. 1), the sphinx (fig. 17 below), and the two anthropoid busts (fig. 18 below) are all small in size. They are of similar provincial workmanship[5] and

3 We may assume that during this period, what was then the temple precinct was surrounded by a wall and access to it was restricted and probably well-guarded, as is known from temples in Egypt. See Valbelle and Bonnet 1996: 80 and Bietak 2021. The wall seen in the plan of Valbelle and Bonnet (1996: plan 5) dates from the New Kingdom. In the Middle Kingdom, the sacred precinct was much smaller. During the days of Amenemhet III, new parts were added to the original shrine.

4 On possible signs of some presence during the Thirteenth Dynasty and the Second Intermediate Period, see Pinch 1993: 55.

5 Petrie (1906: 130–131) has already suggested their related characteristics.

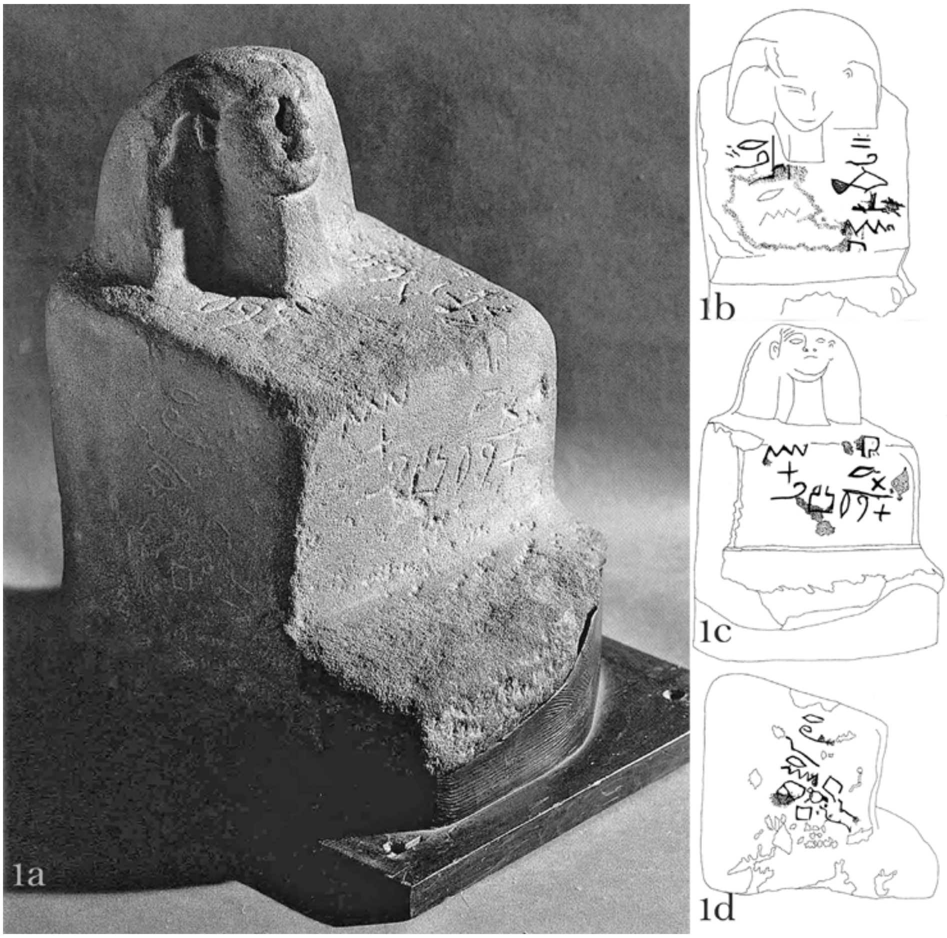



Fig. 1. The block statue Sinai 346 bearing the name *Nʿm rb nqbn* (after Seipel 2003: 166); a) photo; b–d) hand drawings of the inscriptions (after Hamilton 2006: 355) on the flat upper surface of the block (b), on its front (c) and on its right side (d); base 24 × 17 cm; height 30 cm (see also Albright 1969: 17 and Sass 1988: 14, fig. 11)

similar material (sandstone),[6] and their inscriptions show distinct palaeographical connecting threads (see below).

### *1. The Sinai Block Statue 346: Palaeographic Analysis (fig. 1)*

Of the four objects mentioned above, only one — the small block statue (fig. 1) — bears a personal name.[7] It probably belonged to a Canaanite named

6 For refuting Petrie's suggestion that sandstone was used only in the New Kingdom, see already Sinai II: 36–37 and Sass 1988: 137.

7 The root *nʿm*, 'pleasant', is well attested as a component of theophoric Semitic

*Nʿm*, whose title was *rb nqbn* ‘chief miner’. The inscription dedicates the statue to Baʿalat, who was perhaps the original Canaanite goddess worshipped at the Sinai shrine.[8] Block statues of this type, most of them larger, began appearing in Egypt during the Middle Kingdom (see below). However, this little statue is unique because no other Egyptian block statue inscribed in a foreign script is known.

The most comprehensive discussion of the inscriptions on the block statue is found in Sass 1988: 14–15.[9] Two parallel columns of inscription start on the block’s top upper surface and continue down the front. The text in these two columns names the worshipper, the goddess as the recipient, and probably designates the statue as a gift. A third inscription, on the proper right side of the block, clearly repeats the name and gives the title of the worshipper. These inscriptions are discussed in detail below.

### *1.1. The Inscriptions on the Upper Surface and Front Side of the Block Statue*

The writer apparently began the inscription with the left column on the block’s flat upper surface (fig. 1b) and proceeded downwards to the front side (fig. 1c). The fact that the right column on the upper surface ends with a letter carved into the block’s sloping edge (where the upper surface meets the front side) suggests that the writer was already running out of space when cutting the right column on the flat upper surface.

The left column (upper surface and front side) reads (figs. 1b–c):

*ʿl n*[*ʿm*?...] *mt lbʿlt*
‘On behalf of N(uʿmu), a gift for Baʿalat’ (Sass 1988: 15, translation after Albright 1969: 17)

---

names, and appears already in the Ebla texts. In Egyptian it surfaced during the New Kingdom, in the loan compound name *Baʿal-nʿm* (Schneider 1992: 85–86) and in other compounds denoting foreign toponyms (Hoch 1994: 181–182). Sass (1988: 15) cites Albright, who regards *nʿm* on this statue as a personal name, but notes that some researchers disagree with this opinion (see, e.g., Tropper, cited in Seipel 2003: 67–166). Hamilton (2006: 336) also regards it as a personal name.

8 ‘Baʿalat’ appears as the personal name of a Canaanite slave-girl in the Brooklyn Papyrus from the late Middle Kingdom (Hayes 1955: 88, No. 35). Baʿalat was also the Canaanite goddess known to be worshipped in Byblos from the New Kingdom onwards. Hathor was known in Byblos at least since the Middle Kingdom (Chehab 1969). On a possible Canaanite origin of the worship of Hathor in Serabit, see Bietak, in press.

9 Puech (2002: 10–19) has a lengthy discussion of the possible readings of the inscriptions on the statue, but he does not discuss the find itself or its palaeography. See also Hamilton 2006: 335–337 and Morenz 2011: 157–160, who suggest some questionable readings.

The text starts with the (partially erased) phrase *ʿl n*(*ʿm*), ‘on behalf of *Nʿm*’ on the right side of the upper surface. This phrase appears in its entirety again in the inscription on the proper right side (see below). Apparently, the word *lbʿlt* curves to the right on the front (fig. 1c) because the writer noticed he would not have room to complete it, proceeding vertically down the front of the statue.

The right column (upper surface and front side) reads (figs. 1b–c):

*ḏ ldy*[10] *mrʿt*[11]
‘O (thou) in whose care is the meadow’ (Sass 1988: 15, translation after Albright 1969: 17)

The inscription that starts on the right-side column of the flat upper surface goes down and ends on the statue’s front. The writer separated it from the joining, previously inscribed, left column with a bold horizontal line.

The tortuous path of the inscription on the upper surface and front of the block — starting at the left corner of the upper surface and proceeding down the front, and then starting again at the right corner of the upper surface and descending once more[12] — clearly indicates a writer lacking any formal scribal training. The apparent failure in planning, the curving column and, finally, the need to use a separating line would not be deemed acceptable in any Egyptian writing tradition, even in the most peripheral hieroglyphic products. Moreover, when he finally ran out of space for the left column, the writer stood the eye icon (the letter *ʿayin*) in the word *bʿlt* on its tip. A vertical *ʿayin*, which is at odds with a human eye’s natural position and thus with the iconic meaning of the sign, is very rare in the Egyptian lapidary writing system[13] and is unattested in any Egyptian

10 See reading and discussion by Sass (1988: 14). Hamilton (2006: 336–337) suggests a reconstruction as the hieratic numeral 40, resting on his assumption that the inventors of the alphabet were scribes versed in the hieroglyphic and hieratic Egyptian scripts, which contrasts with my theory regarding the invention of the alphabet by illiterate miners (Goldwasser 2015). Hieratic numerals in alphabetic inscriptions appeared in Canaan during Iron Age II (see Goldwasser 1991; 2016a; 2021). For an extensive study of the use of hieratic numerals in Iron Age alphabetic inscriptions in Canaan, see Wimmer 2008: 190–253.

11 If the letter is indeed *bet*, it is possible that the writer omitted the *ʿayin* of the word *bʿlt* to avoid running into the word *bʿlt* in the curving column. In any case, the letter-string *bʿt*, possibly representing the word *bʿlt*, also appears in Inscription 356 from Mine L (Sass 1988: 27, Hamilton 2006: 352).

12 Sass too contends that the writer begins with the left column. As evidence he points to the fact that the *taw* in the right column appears to have been moved slightly to the right in order to accommodate it. Conversely, Puech (2002: 19) and Morenz (2011: 157–158) believe that the inscription begins with the right column.

13 For some rare examples, see Darnell *et al*. 2005: 78, fig. 6.

inscription in Sinai. An Egyptian scribe would have solved the problem very differently by placing flat characters *above* one another. For example, a Middle Kingdom Egyptian stele from the Serabit mines area (fig. 2) features an eye hieroglyph in the last line resting on top of a water hieroglyph. Both signs are horizontal. Another indication of the writer's complete lack of formal scribal training is that cramped for space, he carved one of the letters into the edge of the block, where the upper horizontal surface meets the front vertical surface.

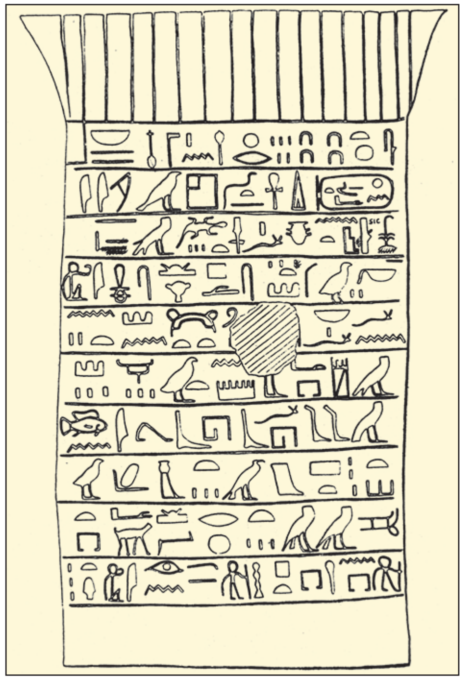


Fig. 2. This Egyptian Middle Kingdom stele from Sinai (Sinai I: pl. XVIII, no. 54) presents standard Egyptian hieroglyphic writing, with flat signs stacked one above the other to fill the row

The most conspicuous letter on the front side of the statue is the *bet* , which forms part of the word *bʿlt*. The letter is a unique iconic representation of a house (or a house floor-plan) with a protruding opening at the top (for more on this variation and its possible origin as a representation of the 'soul houses' of this period, see Goldwasser 2006: 145, fig. 23; Hamilton 2006: 40, fig. 2.4; and below). However, as I show below, the instances of the letter *bet* in the inscription on the proper right side of the statue look quite different.

*1.2. The Inscription on the Proper Right Side of the Block Statue* (figs. 1d and 3)
The text reads:

*ʿl nʿm rb nqbn(m)*[14]
'On behalf of Nuʿmu, chief of the miner[s]' (Albright 1969: 17)

As noted above, the inscription on the block's upper surface (now partially erased) already mentions the protagonist's name, *N*[*ʿm*]. The inscription on the proper right side nevertheless repeats it, underscoring his identity and indicating his high status as *rb nqbn*.

The inscription starts at the top of the block's right-side surface, proceeds

14 Albright (1969: 42) reads here *rb nqbn(m)* after Sinai 349.

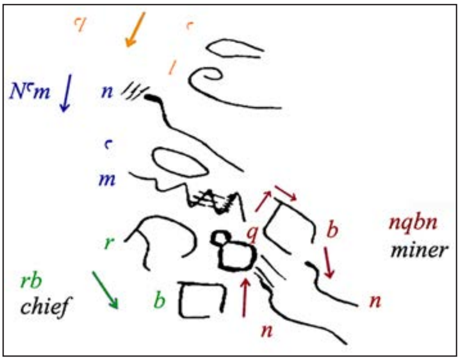
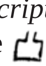



Fig. 3. The inscription on the right side of the block statue (Sinai 346); circles separating words and arrows indicating the direction of reading added by the author (drawings after Sass 1988: fig. 14, taken from Grimme 1923); the photograph of fig. 1a above gives the impression of a somewhat different head (*resh*) sign with a neckline

down this surface, and then curves upwards and down again, as indicated in fig. 3.

Such a zigzagging path is not known from any hieroglyphic inscription in Egypt. It is not an example of boustrophedon or any other regular, systematic direction of writing but suggests, once again, a writer untrained in any script of the period. It is unclear why he chose this layout when he had enough room to create parallel lines or columns. However, a certain logic may be discerned in his choices if they are taken to be divorced from any established or standard writing tradition. Perhaps placing the word *nqbn* beside the word *rb* served to designate the title as a single unit, separate from the personal name *Nʿm*. Also interesting is the rather significant gap between the words *ʿl* and *Nʿm*; such a gap between words is not attested in any other early alphabetic inscription in Sinai. Only in the second part of the second millennium BCE were words in alphabetic inscriptions first separated by dots or lines (Naveh 1973; Goldwasser 2016a: 152–153).[15] However, this space may be an accidental feature.

*1.3. The Letter Bet on the Block Statue 346 Inscriptions*

The shape of the *bet* on the front of the statue  (see also fig. 1c) is the most blatantly 'non-Egyptian' form of *bet* found in Sinai or elsewhere. It is not borrowed from the repertoire of Egyptian hieroglyphs because no such hieroglyph exists. Instead, it is a clear example of a new alphabetic image created by the alphabet's inventors to represent a house. Pronounced ***bet** in their Semitic dialect, it is used as a signifier for the first consonant of this word, *b*. Containing over a dozen

15 The earliest alphabetic inscription featuring a clear word separation is the Lachish ewer inscription, which is several centuries later than the Sinai inscriptions. The separator takes the form of three vertical dots. Sass (1988: 61) argues convincingly that the dots appear on the ewer only once because, in the rest of the short inscription, the images function as word dividers. Similar dots appear in the later ostracon from Khirbet Qeiyafa (Sass *et al*. 2015: fig. 13). Interestingly, in Rock Inscription 2 from Wadi el-Ḥôl, the words in the compound (?) *pk-ʾl* are separated by a space. On this inscription, see Darnell *et al*. 2005; Goldwasser 2006: 146–151; Hamilton 2006: 327–330; see also Sass 2008.

instances of the letter *bet*, the Sinai alphabetic inscriptions illustrate the diversity of variants initially associated with this letter.[16] In this early stage of the script's development, there were evidently several competing icons for 'house' (fig. 4), all of them different from the house hieroglyph used in the Egyptian script of the period (fig. 5).

The inscription on the proper right side of the statue (figs. 1c and 3) contains two more instances of the letter *bet*. The one in the word *rb* takes the most common form of this letter in the Proto-Sinaitic inscriptions, namely a square with a tiny opening in one corner: . The second *bet*, in the word *nqbn*, seems to take the shape of a square with a relatively large opening in the corner  or [17] (see also fig. 1d).

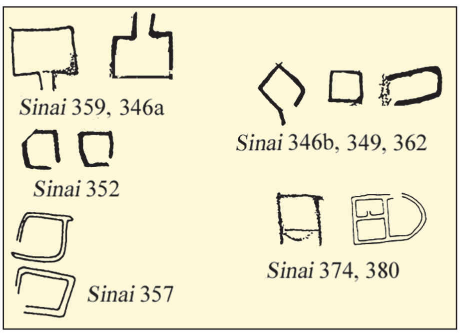



Fig. 4. The different forms of the letter *bet* in various alphabetic inscriptions in Sinai (after Goldwasser 2006: 143)

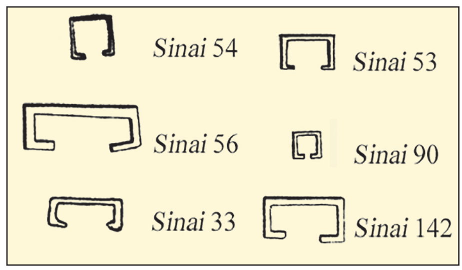



Fig. 5. Variants of the 'house' hieroglyph, with the sound value *pr* in Egyptian, from Middle Kingdom inscriptions in Sinai (Sinai I: pls. XII [33], XVII [53], XVIII [54, 56], XXVI [90], LIII [142])

Another possible *bet* (if it is indeed a *bet*) is less distinct on the edge of the block between the upper and front surfaces (figs. 1a–b). What might be the right side of this letter is still clearly visible on the block's upper surface, and the opening is visible on the front side surface, but the left part of the letter is indistinct. What looks like the left part of the *bet* in Grimme's (1923) photograph seems to be, according to Sass, a flaw in the stone (Sass 1988: fig. 13). The photograph in Seipel's publication clearly shows two parallel lines, the exact nature of which is hard to determine.[18] Sass (1988: 14) firmly contends that this is the letter *resh*, represented by a head icon, rather than a *bet* represented by a house with an entrance.[19]

The presence of multiple forms of the same letter on a single statue may be

16 See detailed discussions in Goldwasser 2006: 134, 143–146; 2012: 5–6.
17 It is difficult to judge if the downwards line indeed exists.
18 For a new colour photograph of the side of the block statue, see Seipel 2003: 167.
19 Sass concluded this after examining the statue itself in Cairo.

due either to two different hands or to a single writer using a flexible inventory of alternative letter models. Born outside any institutional system, the earliest alphabet apparently allowed different pictorial models for the same letter.[20] From the earliest writers' point of view, as long as the icon was pictorially identifiable and could lead the reader to the word it represented and from there to the sound it stood for, it could serve as a sign in the new script system. The final semiotic step was the divorcing of the image from its original meaning and using it solely to represent the word's first sound. All versions of the early *bet* signs on the block statue 346 could safely lead a reader on this semiotic road. All icons clearly evoke simplified house drawings (see Goldwasser 2016a for a detailed discussion). Only a few hundred years later, the icons of the newly invented letters slowly become more linear. Extensive standardization was not reached even when professional scribes adopt the script by the end of the Bronze Age in the southern Shephelah (Finkelstein and Sass 2013; Goldwasser 2016a).

### *1.4. The Reading Direction and Orientation of the Letters on Nʿm's Statue*

The top surface and front of *Nʿm*'s statue provide only three signs with a clear directional orientation: the serpent (*nun*), the fish, and the head (*resh*), all facing to the right. On the proper right side of the statue (see fig. 3), the iconic signs with a clear orientation, such as the *resh* and the *nun*, likewise face in a consistent direction. However, here they all face to the left, opposite from the signs on the upper surface and front side. Particularly interesting is the letter *lamed* in the word *ʿl*, which appears twice on the statue: on the top and the side. As shown in fig. 6, the two *lamed*s are mirror images of one another.

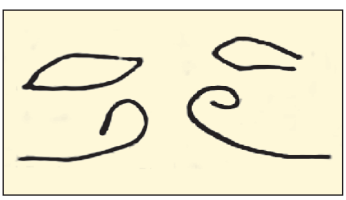


Fig. 6. The word *ʿl* as inscribed on the statue's upper surface, featuring the letter *lamed* with the curl on the right, and the same word as inscribed on the side of the statue, featuring a 'mirror image' *lamed* with the curl on the left (after Sass 1988: fig. 11)

Egyptian texts show a consistent orientation of signs within a word or phrase. However, consistent letter orientation — even within the same phrase or word — is not a feature of the Proto-Sinaitic alphabetic inscriptions: several of these inscriptions fail to exhibit such consistency. In inscription 358, for example (fig. 7), the bull and the fish face in opposite directions. This tendency is another factor that points to illiteracy.

The *qof* in the inscription on the side of *Nʿm*'s statue may seem tilted  (see fig. 3), but it preserves its iconicity (assuming it represents a monkey) since it is

20 For the intriguing case of the *dalet*, see Goldwasser 2021.

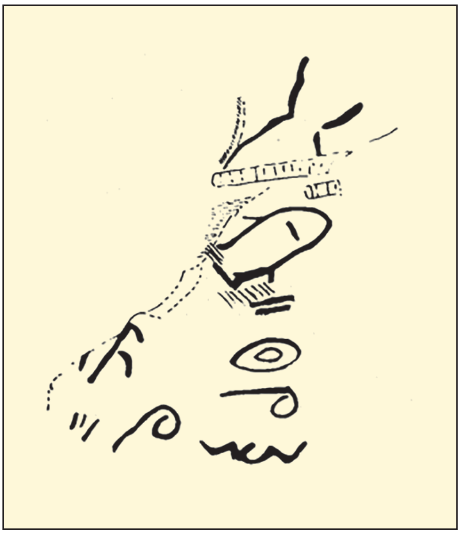


Fig. 7. Alphabetic rock inscription from Mine M (Sinai 358) with signs facing in opposite directions: the bull facing left and the fish facing right (after Sass 1988: no. 63)

Fig. 8. Sinai rock inscription 351: image of the god Ptah with a Proto-Sinaitic inscription featuring a horizontal *qof* letter (after Hamilton 2006: 343)

vertical if one considers the direction of reading (which is diagonally upwards at this point). Conversely, in Sinai 351 (fig. 8), the writer chose to disregard the sign's iconic meaning, for he drew it lying on its side. Baboon figurines were part of the Egyptian scribe's paraphernalia,[21] and the inventors of the alphabet may have been aware of the association between the baboon and the art of writing. However, the early examples of the letter *qof*, composed of a small circle atop a larger one, look less like the animal itself and more like a schematic representation of monkey statuettes frequently found in middle-class tombs during the Middle Kingdom in Egypt. An example is a statuette found in excavations at Lisht and dated to the Thirteenth–Fourteenth Dynasties (fig. 9a). It is approximately the same size as *Nʿm*'s block statue and the Sinai sphinx. Like other Egyptian monkey statues, it deviates from the typical Egyptian form in that the head is turned slightly sideways.[22] In this context, it is noteworthy that

21 See, for example, the 'scribe's outfit' in Carnarvon *et al*. 1912: pl. LXVI.

22 Statuettes of monkeys other than baboons are attested in Egyptian art from the Old Kingdom period onwards. They are represented in various postures, but always with the head turned sideways (see, e.g., a statue from the early Middle Kingdom period in the Metropolitan Museum in New York, no. 66.99.155; a monkey statue from the New Kingdom in the Brooklyn Museum, no. 48.181, and another statue in the same museum, no. 1991.3, from the early third millennium BCE, found in Susa, Iran. I thank Diana Craig-Patch for these references.


Fig. 9. a) Limestone monkey statuette from the Middle Kingdom, found in Lisht, Egypt, 1933–1934; height 10.5 cm (photo courtesy of the Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York, the Rogers Foundation, 1934 [34.1.179]); b) monkey figurine (sandstone) found by Petrie in Sinai (Petrie 1906: 127)

Bourriau, who studied the pottery from Serabit el-Khadem, believes that potters from Egypt's Lisht region produced the Middle Kingdom Egyptian ceramics found at this site.[23] Monkey figurines may have been brought to Sinai by scribes, potters or other artisans, or produced on-site, like the sandstone baboon figurine found by Petrie (fig. 9b).

Such statuettes or figurines, quite abstract in form, are closer in shape to the *qof* in the Proto-Sinaitic alphabet. It should also be borne in mind that monkeys were an essential cultural motif during the Middle Kingdom period, not only in Egypt but throughout the ancient Near East, from Ebla through Aphek to Tell

23 '[A] group of professional potters existed at Serabit el-Khadim in the Twelfth–early Thirteenth Dynasty… They came from the Memphite/Faiyum region, we may presume, perhaps from the workshops of the Residence at Lisht, since it is where the pottery style we have identified originated…' (Bourriau 1996: 31).

el-Dabʿa.[24] It is possible that all these factors contributed to the choice of the monkey to represent the sound ק.

*1.5. Between the Inscriptions on Nʿm's Statue and the Alphabetic Inscriptions by the Mines*

The letters of the inscriptions on *Nʿm*'s statue are similar in some of their palaeographic features to the letters of Sinai inscription 349, at the entrance of Mine L (fig. 10).

As mentioned above, Mines L and M yielded the most significant number of alphabetic inscriptions and the longest and clearest ones. Inscription 349 from Mine L reflects the highest level of writing skill. It is quite long, consisting of seven lines, about half of which are still legible. It is the only inscription that features baselines in apparent imitation of Egyptian hieroglyphic inscriptions. The baselines prompted the writer to keep the letters similar in size, and he made an effort to match their shape to the space between the lines and to position them symmetrically within it. For example, the three serpent icons (representing the letter *nun*) are more or less equidistant from the lines above and below them, as are the water icon (*mem*) and the square house icons (*bet*). The writer is also careful to keep the letters consistent in their direction, as in Egyptian inscriptions.

Fig. 10. Alphabetic inscription Sinai 349 from Mine L (Sass 1988: fig. 27; cf. Hamilton 2006: 339)

Nonetheless, Sinai inscription 349 also has several distinctly non-Egyptian features. First, the letters are consistently ordered in a linear fashion, side by

24 See Scandone Matthiae (2004: 190–201) and Matthiae, Pinnock and Scandone Matthiae (1995: 464–465, 505) in Ebla. See Kopetzky and Bietak (2016: 360–368) for a 'green jasper' seal impression (TD 9402H) featuring a row of monkeys, and Beck and Na'aman (2002: 288–290) for another 'green jasper' seal impression from Aphek with a similar row of monkeys. A larger statue of the god Thoth was found at the Serabit temple; see Valbelle and Bonnet 1996: 56, fig. 71. For more on the letter *qof*, see Puech 2002: 15, n. 34. For another, less feasible, suggestion that the letter represents the eye of a needle, see Yardeni 1983: 48.

side, whereas Egyptian inscriptions always feature characters stacked vertically to avoid leaving empty spaces within the line (see fig. 2 above). Even more strikingly, the writer violates another primary rule of Egyptian hieroglyphic writing, although, being unable to read Egyptian, he was probably unaware of this. While in Egyptian, the letters generally face in the opposite direction from the direction of reading (fig. 11), in this alphabetic inscription, they face 'forward', in the direction of reading, thus countering the customary Egyptian writing direction.

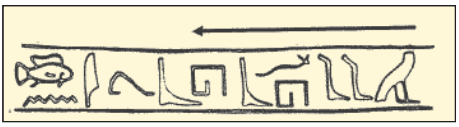


Fig. 11. The direction of reading Egyptian hieroglyphs: the signs representing people and animals face towards the beginning of the line (after Sinai I: pl. XVIII, no. 54; cf. fig. 2 above)

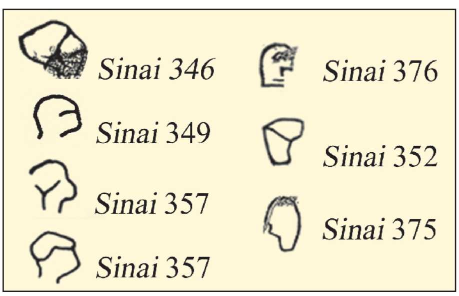



Fig. 12. Variants of the head (*resh*) icon from Sinai alphabetic inscriptions (after examples by Sass 1988: table 4; see also Hamilton 2006: 223–224, 267)

The title *rb nqbn*, which appears on the block statue, also appears in Sinai inscription 349.[25] The letter *resh* (the head icon) resembles the typical Egyptian hieroglyph of a head with a kind of defined hairline in both inscriptions.[26] Other Sinai alphabetic inscriptions feature different head icons (e.g., fig. 12 — Sinai 375 and Sinai 376).

As for the letter *bet*, inscription 349 uses the form of this letter that is commonest in the Sinai alphabetic inscriptions: a simple square representing a building , similar to the one on the proper right side of the block statue. The two instances of this letter in Sinai 349 are identical, as are most of the other signs that occur more than once; the consistent representation of the letters in Sinai 349 is another indication of the writer's high level of proficiency,

25 *Nʿm* does not seem to be mentioned in this inscription. Perhaps several individuals bore this title simultaneously.

26 It is noteworthy that not one of the Canaanite examples of the letter *resh* features the 'Egyptian beard', as in the canonical form of the hieroglyph. However, Egyptian hieroglyphic inscriptions from Sinai feature both a bearded and a beardless variant of this hieroglyph (Goldwasser 2006: 155). A conspicuous non-Egyptian model for the letter *resh* in the form of a head with the Canaanite mushroom headdress,  appears in an inscription from Wadi el-Ḥôl (Darnell *et al.* 2005: 83, fig. 16; Goldwasser 2006: 146–147; Hamilton 2006: 221–231). The Canaanite mushroom headdress is unknown in the hieroglyphic writing system and could be considered an excellent example for my 'reproduction theory' as presented in Goldwasser 2016a.

compared to the creators of other alphabetic inscriptions in Sinai. An extreme example of an inscription that does not display such consistency is Sinai 374, from Mine M (fig. 13). The phrase *mʾhb bʿlt* appears in Sinai 374 in full, unlike on the sphinx Sinai 345 (see below). The letter *bet* appears once as a square with an opening in the corner and once in a unique variant, which — assuming Hamilton's transcription is accurate (Hamilton 2006: 48, 371) — looks like a domed building drawn upside-down: . As there is no word separation in the alphabetic inscription, the use of two different pictorial variants of the letter *bet* may have been a desirable and deliberate action on the part of the writer in order to avoid having two identical signs adjacent to one another.[27]

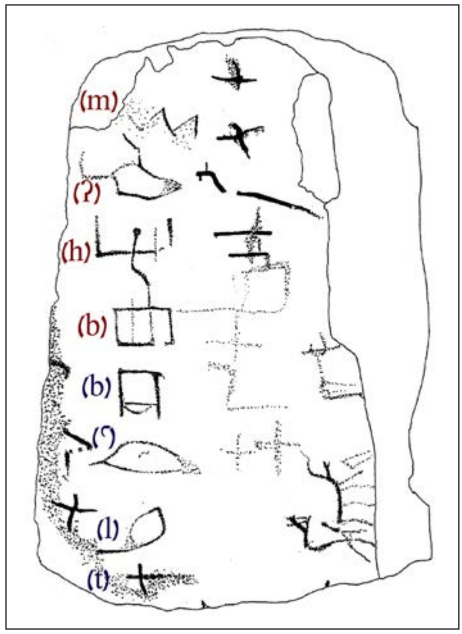
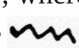



Fig. 13. Two different forms of the letter *bet* in the same inscription? (Sinai 374, after Hamilton 2006: 371 with my letter readings); the left (centre) column reads *mʾhb bʿlt*, displaying two adjacent instances of the letter *bet*, each represented by a different icon

The block statue Sinai 346 (fig. 1 above) and the inscription Sinai 349 (see below) both feature an eye icon (the letter *ʿayin*) without a pupil. Other alphabetic inscriptions feature very different eye icons, probably inscribed by different hands (fig. 14).

Returning now to our comparison with inscription 349 from Mine L (fig. 10 above), where the water icon (*mem*) appears twice and has only three and a half ripples , whereas the block statue features a variant with four ripples . The monkey icon (*qof*) on the block statue  is similar to the one in inscription 349 , composed of a small circle on top of a larger one. The apparent 'tail' of the *qof* on the statue is probably a flaw in the stone.[28]

27 In the sphinx Sinai 345 (see fig. 17a), the *bet* appears only once, suggesting that, according to the rationale of the writer, the same sign could serve twice — as the last letter in the word *mʾhb* and as the first letter in the word *bʿlt* — especially when space is constrained.

28 Hamilton includes the tail in his transcription whereas Sass does not (cf. Sass 1988: tables 11, 14, and our fig. 10).

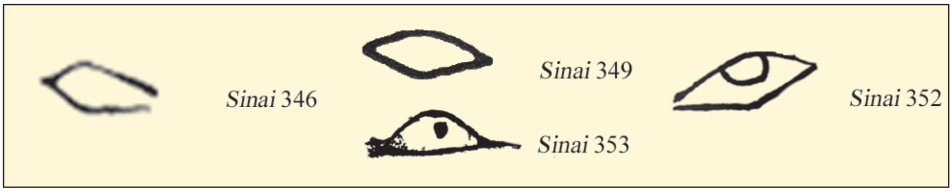



Fig. 14. Different forms of the eye icon (the letter *ayin*) from the Sinai alphabetic inscriptions (after Hamilton 2006: 183–184, 335).

*1.6. The Letter Bet in the Form of a House with an Entrance: A Link between N'm's Statue and Inscription 359 in Mine L*

As noted above, the rare variant of the letter *bet* which appears on the block statue is believed to represent a house with an entrance. However, it may also imitate a house model like those placed as offerings in graves, a well-documented practice during the Middle Kingdom (fig. 15).[29]

The only other distinct example of this variant of *bet*, apart from the one on *N'm*'s statue, appears in rock inscription 359 (fig. 16) at the entrance of Mine L (Sass 1988: 30). It shows the same model .

Fig. 15. Model of a house with a shape resembling the letter *bet* in the form of a house with an entrance , Egypt, Middle Kingdom; height 17 cm, length 27 cm, width 27 cm (photo courtesy of the Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York, gift of the Egyptian Research Foundation and the British School of Archeology in Egypt, 1907, 07.231.11)

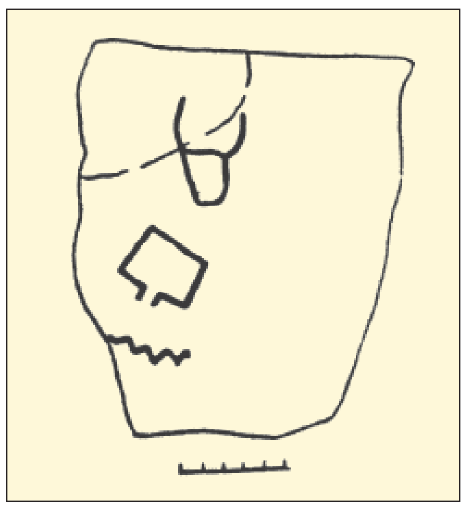


Fig. 16. The rare variant of *bet* representing a square building with an entrance, in inscription Sinai 359 at the entrance of Mine L (after Sass 1988: fig. 65)

29 See earlier discussions in Goldwasser 2006: 143–146 and 2016a: 129, with additional bibliography.

Rock inscription 359 consists of only three letters, but all are very neatly drawn, similar in proportions and regularly spaced. The letter *bet* in this inscription has the ‘entrance’ at the bottom of the sign, rather than at the top as on *Nʿm*’s statue, again illustrating the flexible stance of the Proto-Sinaitic letters. Perhaps this particular variant   was favoured by a specific individual within the inventors’ circle.

Concluding the comparative discussion of the palaeography of the inscription on the block statue 346, we may suggest that it bears, in general, a palaeographic resemblance to the ‘high quality’ inscriptions of Mine L. While poorly positioned and organised on the statue’s surface, the inscription comprises several phrases, with the letters fairly consistent in size and orientation, especially on the proper right side inscription. The letter on the statue that carries the most striking resemblance to the inscriptions in Mine L is the *bet* variant in the shape of a house with an entrance. The example on the block statue 346  and the one in Inscription 359  are the only known examples of this rare early variant in the whole Proto-Canaanite repertoire. They form a clear link between the block statue found in the temple of Hathor and the alphabetic inscriptions of Mine L. This idiosyncratic *bet* suggests a close connection between the producers of the inscriptions in the mines and the inscribed objects found in the temple.

### *2. The Sphinx Sinai 345: Palaeographic Analysis (fig. 17)*

The alphabetic and hieroglyphic inscriptions on the sphinx are dealt with separately below.

#### *2.1. The Alphabetic Inscriptions*

In my earlier publications, I dubbed the small sphinx ‘the Rosetta Stone of the alphabet’. This bilingual inscription provided Egyptologist Alan Gardiner in 1916 with the key to decipher the alphabetic script of the Sinai inscriptions.[30] Unlike the majority of linguists of Semitic languages who later studied the early alphabet during the twentieth century (except for Sass 1988), Gardiner insisted that the alphabet was invented in Sinai and that the invention had taken place during the Middle Kingdom, rather than later, during the Hyksos period or the New Kingdom.[31]

30 For a recent discussion of the sphinx and its reading, see Wilson-Wright 2013.

31 See Gardiner 1916, who firmly reiterated his Middle Kingdom dating in Gardiner 1961. Sass was of the same opinion in 1988, but in later publications changed his mind (see, e.g., Sass 2004/5; 2008). See Bothmer and others in Sass 1988: 136, 138, with n. 92. Bothmer strongly insisted on a Middle Kingdom date for the sphinx and the block statue. Cross (1989: 80) follows Petrie’s dating of *c*. 1500 without discussion, and so did Naveh in his book (1987: 26).


Fig. 17. The small female sphinx statue (Sinai 345), the ‘Rosetta Stone’ of the alphabet, bearing an inscription in Egyptian hieroglyphs and its counterpart in the alphabetic script (base 14 × 24 cm; height 15 cm; photos of the sphinx courtesy of the British Museum, London); above the pictures is an annotated copy of the alphabetic inscriptions on the two sides of the sphinx (Goldwasser 2010: 42)

The proper right side of the sphinx reads:

*mʾhb*[*b*]*ʿlt*
‘Beloved of Baʿalat’[32] (Sass 1988: 12)

The inscription runs from left to right towards the right paw of the sphinx.

The alphabetic letters on the proper right side (Fig. 17a) are reasonably identical in size and of rather good quality. Their orientation is difficult to determine, except in the case of the *aleph* (a bull icon) which faces right. Here too, however, the direction of reading is ‘wrong’ in Egyptian terms since it proceeds from left to right, i.e., in the same direction the ox icon (*aleph)* is facing. The letter *bet* takes the ‘standard’ form of a simple square, as in inscription 349 and on the block statue’s proper right side.

The letter *he* with a single leg that appears on the sphinx is also known from Sinai 356 at Mine L’s entrance, in which the title *rb nqbn* can be reconstructed.[33] The ‘one-legged’ *he* also appears in Sinai 374, discovered in nearby Mine M (fig. 13 above; Sass 1988: 36).

A significant feature shared by the sphinx and the block statue 346 discussed above is the vertically positioned eye icon (*ʿayin*), which appears on both objects as part of the word *bʿlt*. The same vertical *ʿayin* appears on the proper left side of the sphinx. The two examples on the sphinx have a pupil, whereas their counterpart on the block statue lacks a pupil. As stated above, a vertical eye icon is unknown in the Sinai hieroglyphic inscriptions and is exceedingly rare in Egypt as well. Nor does it appear in any alphabetic Sinai inscriptions other than those on the block statue and the sphinx. This idiosyncrasy establishes a strong palaeographic link between these two artefacts from the Hathor shrine — the block statue and the sphinx— which are the two most sophisticated small finds bearing alphabetic inscriptions to have been discovered in Sinai.

The proper left side reads:

[?…]*lbʿlt*
‘For Baʿalat’ (Sass 1988: 13, with earlier discussions)

This line of inscription runs from left to right, but here in the opposite direction on the sphinx — from the paw to the hind leg.

The letters on this side (fig. 17b) are very similar to the letters on the proper right side of the sphinx. The vertical *ʿayin* appears again (discussed above) and

32 Read here a sandhi writing, see Wilson-Wright 2013: 143, along with a linguistic discussion of the inscription. He reconstructs an Egyptian loanword before *lbʿlt*.

33 See Sass 1988: pl. 4; also Rainey 1975: 109, n. 17; Hamilton 2006: 352. See also inscription 353, after Sass 1988, pls. 45–46.

the *bet* follows the ‘standard’ model of the square known also in the block statue. Two *lamed*s in the phrase *lbʿlt* are very similar to the *lamed*s on the block statue 346. The letters before this phrase are problematic.[34]

*2.2. The Hieroglyphic Inscriptions on the Sphinx (fig. 17a)*

On the proper right side of the sphinx’s body an Egyptian hieroglyphic inscription *mry ḥwt-ḥr nbt* (*m*)*fkꜣt*, ‘Beloved of Hathor Lady of Turquoise’ appears.[35] The Egyptian inscription, even if not of the best hieroglyphs, obeys Egyptian writing rules. It is read from right to left. According to Egyptian rules, the hieroglyphic phrase shows honorific transposition. The word *mry* ‘beloved’ is moved to the end of the phrase, and the goddess’ name and her epithet appear first. The hieroglyphs in the inscription are written in the Egyptian way, one above the other with classifiers and plural strokes. A single anomaly is the form of the bird in the hieroglyphic combination that stands for *ḥwt-ḥr* = Hathor. It strongly resembles an owl, while the correct hieroglyph should be a falcon. Hathor is metaphorically described as ‘the abode of Horus’, being his mother, so the choice of hieroglyphs, in this case, is meaningful. This incorrect variation of ‘owl in the abode’ is scarce in Egypt, and may point to production by a foreigner.[36] Below the hieroglyphs, the alphabetic phrase echoes the Egyptian in Canaanite[37] ‘beloved of Baʿalat’. This parallel alphabetic phrase is, however, written in the opposite direction, from left to right. On the front part of the sphinx, on the animal’s chest, a puzzling, simplified Serekh appears, including three signs. This ancient depiction of a royal building served in the Old Kingdom before the cartouche to signal a royal name. However, the Serekh continues to appear later, during the Middle Kingdom as well. Two signs on the Serekh of the sphinx could be identified as Egyptian hieroglyphs: the falcon (Horus) above the Serekh, and the sickle *mꜣ* within the Serekh. The third sign by the falcon could hardly be identified as an Egyptian hieroglyph. During the Middle Kingdom, the Serekh may be used to represent the first name of the king, called the ‘Horus name’. This name is preceded by the epithet ‘Horus’ marked by a falcon-Horus hieroglyph above the building, as in the case of the Sinai sphinx. Within the Serekh, however, a royal name should

34 See a recent discussion in Wilson-Wright 2013.

35 For the discussion of turquoise in Sinai, see Morenz 2009.

36 For a detailed discussion of this anomaly, see Goldwasser 2006: 124–129. Wilson-Wright (2013) suggests a circle of optional alphabet users in Sinai, besides the miners. Such candidates would be dragomans or Egyptian administrators of Semitic origins. Such people could understand and appreciate the alluring invention. It is possible that such a person was involved in the production of the hieroglyphic inscription of Khebeded in stele no. 92; see Goldwasser 2006: 151.

37 By using ‘Canaanite’ I refer to the Semitic dialect that was put down in writing in Sinai. The identification of the specific Semitic variant represented in the inscriptions is still debated; see recently Wilson-Wright 2013.

appear. As is, the Serekh on the sphinx does not refer to any correct Egyptian royal name of any period, and it shows a single hieroglyph 𓌳. Nevertheless, the sickle hieroglyph makes part of the Throne Name of Amenemhet III, the most commonly used name of this king, well known in Sinai. Yet the Throne Name (the fourth name of the king) is not written in a Serekh but within a cartouche during this period, so even if the inscription hints at an attribution to Amenemhet III, its use is flawed.

To sum up this thorny discussion of the Egyptian inscriptions on the little sphinx, there is a possibility that the person who wrote the Egyptian part of the inscription was not well versed in hieroglyphic writing. The owl that exchanges the Horus bird in the name of Hathor is an incorrect spelling. The Horus above the Serekh is correct, but the sickle hieroglyph does not make a proper match within the Serekh for a royal name. The third sign by the Horus bird is undecipherable. It is difficult to determine whether the alphabetic inscription was written simultaneously with the Egyptian inscription or as a later secondary inscription. The fact that the alphabetic inscription below the *mry ḥwt-ḥr nbt* (*m*) *fkꜣt* is a 'translation' into Canaanite of the first part of the Egyptian phrase may point to some interference during the writing process. However, one should be very cautious, as the phrase *mʾhb*[*b*]*ʿlt* is the most popular phrase in the Proto-Sinaitic corpus.

### *3. The Two Miniature Anthropoid Busts (Sinai 347, 347a): Palaeographic Analysis (fig. 18)*

Petrie found two similar, miniature anthropoid busts made of sandstone in the area of the Hathor shrine, both bearing alphabetic inscriptions. One of the two (fig. 18b) is in rather poor condition.


Fig. 18. The two miniature anthropoid busts; a) Sinai 347, bearing a clear, well-executed inscription reading *tnt* 'gift'; it may also be a very early record of the Canaanite goddess Tanit (after Gardiner 1916: 12; Butin 1932: pl. XIII; Sass 1988: figs. 18, 21), base 11 × 7 cm, height 7 cm; b) Sinai 347a, bearing traces of an inscription *lb*.… perhaps part of the phrase *lbʿlt* (after Albright 1969: 17; Butin 1932: pl. XIII; Sass 1988: figs. 19, 22), base 13.5 × 8.5 cm, height 7 cm (Sass 1988: 15)

*3.1. The Sinai 347 Bust (fig. 18a)*

The short inscription on bust statuette 347 (figs. 18a and 20a), which reads *tnt*, possibly 'gift',[38] is well executed by a skilled hand. The two instances of the letter *tav* are nearly identical in size and orientation, placed neatly one above the other, just at the centre of the bust, and equidistant from the horizontal serpent icon (*nun*) between them.

*3.2. The Sinai 347a Bust (fig. 18b)*

The similar Sinai bust 347a is in poorer condition. It bears only two legible letters: *lamed* and *bet*, perhaps the initial letters of the most common phrase in the Sinai alphabetic inscriptions, *lb[ʿlt]*. However, in this statue, the preserved inscription is on the proper left side, suggesting that it originally contained another column, on the right side, now lost. As shown in fig. 18b, the *lamed* is positioned above the centre of the letter *bet* showing the writer's same careful attitude as in the better preserved Sinai 347.[39]

## ARCHAEOLOGICAL CONTEXT, MATERIALITY, TEXT AND AGENCY

The four small sandstone artefacts bearing alphabetic inscriptions, found in the Egyptian temple, reflect a locally made provincial corpus of objects that imitate Egyptian prototypes. Their alphabetic inscriptions show a relatively high level of writing skills (longer texts), technical command (size of letters, spaces) and sometimes aesthetic considerations. Due to their close workmanship and shared palaeographic characteristics, they were most probably manufactured by a particular group of people or a specific person active in Serabit at a certain point in time. They might have been produced during a single expedition or even on a single occasion (e.g., a religious festival for the goddess). The four objects presented by the Canaanites are also unique in the topics they represented. The repertoire of the Egyptian votive finds from Hathor temples is well known and studied and exhibits hundreds of examples.[40] Yet sphinxes, block statues, or 'ancestor figurines' do not compose part of this repertoire.

It may be a mere coincidence that this relatively homogeneous group of artefacts was found in a limited area close to the Hathor shrine. Yet it is equally possible that this little collection was hidden in a cache in the area and was somehow disturbed by Petrie's work. The surviving hieroglyphic inscriptions within the

38 Another possible reading is Tanit, referring to the Canaanite goddess. However, this goddess is known only much later; see discussion in Sass 1988: 15–16.

39 The drawing of the inscription on 347a is not accurate. There is enough space for the reconstruction of *lb*[*ʿlt*].

40 See the detailed study, Pinch 1993.

Hathor shrine include Middle Kingdom texts of the Egyptian officials. It may be worth noting that the Egyptian head of the fifteenth Egyptian expedition, *ʾImny Šsn*, is recorded in hieroglyphs on a few finds in the shrine (Valbelle and Bonnet 1996: 25–26; Tallet 2018: 180). This high Egyptian official explicitly declares his Canaanite origin (by mentioning his Canaanite mother) in his hieroglyphic inscriptions. [41]

One could hypothesize that Canaanite groups of mine workers in Serabit comprised professional miners and probably less-skilled workers hired as a designated workforce who most likely lived in the area of the mines. These workers, some of them highly skilled, might have had only limited access to the temple compound. Since they did not form part of the official Egyptian administration, they were not given the privilege to add their names and titles in hieroglyphs to Egyptian stelae, a privilege granted to the Canaanite 'donkey drivers' that made up part of the official Egyptian expedition.[42] Bussmann (2017: 79) suggests that offering a votive figurine in Egypt may well have been a practice restricted to the upper echelons of village and town communities. However, some of the miners may have been granted special favours by the Egyptians or their fellow Canaanites in the official administration, perhaps due to a successful season. One such favour may permit the chief miners to present votive gifts to the great goddess in her shrine on a particular occasion. Offering gifts to the gods in the temple was a known Canaanite costume. The Canaanite miners, who, at least at some point, were experimenting with a new script they had invented for their own Semitic language, added some lines in their new script to their votive gifts. In any case, these inscriptions make these finds unique, as Middle Kingdom Egyptian objects bearing a text in a foreign language written in a foreign script are not known otherwise. It seems that they were placed in the temple as ex-votos, acting as long-term agents of their owners in the shrine. An ex-voto may serve as an individual's agent when a ritual is performed (el-Damaty 1990: 10; Verbovsek 2007: 258; Schulz 2011: 6). The existence of these four objects in the shrine area becomes even more meaningful if we take into account the comment of Pinch (1993: 55) that there is a 'complete absence' of small Middle Kingdom objects in Sinai that could be identified as votive offerings of 'ordinary people'.

At this stage, we would like to ask some concluding questions. To what extent were the producers of the alphabetic inscriptions aware of the traditional roles such objects held in the source Egyptian culture? Was the form of the object meaningful for them? What is the relationship between the objects and the alphabetic text they carry? What were their expectations from the small artefacts?

41 Giveon believed that shrine was originally intended as a tomb for Ameny (Giveon 1978: 54). Another individual named *Šsn* is known from Ezbet Rushdi; see Fischer-Elfert and Grimm 2003.

42 For a detailed discussion on the donkey riders in the temple reliefs and their cultural context, see Goldwasser 2013.

***Materiality: The Block Statue 346***[43]

Perhaps due to his status as a chief miner, the Canaanite *Nʿm* was given special permission to place his statue, bearing his name, title and prayer, written in his own language and script, in the temple precinct of Hathor-Baʿalat. In this way, he could continue to ‘participate’ in the worship at the temple.

Both Bothmer (cited in Sass 1988: 138) and Schulz (1992: 295) confidently date this Sinai block statue to the Middle Kingdom. Since it is small and of relatively poor quality, Russmann regards it as a ‘local copy’.[44] Two somewhat similar statues (also in size), from the Middle Kingdom were found in Egypt (Sass 1988: 138; Schulz 1992: 305), both of them depicting a seated figure wearing a kind of robe. However, both of these statues are of typical Egyptian craftsmanship. The first (fig. 19a) bears an inscription on its upper surface and, like the block statue 346, shows no representation of the feet. In the second (fig. 19b), the beard rests directly on the block’s upper surface, making the block


Fig. 19. Block statues from the Middle Kingdom, Egypt; a) bearing the name and title of the owner on the block’s upper surface, height 30 cm; b) with beard ‘flowing’ into the robe, height 22 cm (after Schulz 1992: pl. 77b and 77e respectively)

43 For an earlier discussion of the block statue 346, see Goldwasser 2016b.

44 On Russmann’s view of the statue, see letter cited in Hamilton 2006: 301–302, n. 36.

a continuation of the beard, just like in *Nʿm*'s statue. However, Dorothea Arnold — who likewise dates the statue to the late Middle Kingdom — notes that in *Nʿm*'s statue the beard does not grow out of the tip of the figure's chin, as is usually the case in Egyptian statues, but closer to the figure's neck.[45] The Sinai statue also differs from Egyptian block statues in that the neck is unusually long. Its head is titled upwards, a rare but known posture in such Middle Kingdom block statues.[46] The overall shape of the Sinai statue is very abstract, and its lines are very sharp and square. These features, taken together, make for a low level of 'Egyptianness'.[47] The fact that the block statuette nonetheless had an Egyptian appearance probably increased its prestige value in the eyes of the Canaanite users.[48]

At first glance, the main topics presented in the inscription on the block statue fit the texts of similar objects in Egyptian culture. In this Egyptian statue genre, the statue's text carries the owner's name and title. Additionally, in many Egyptian examples, it contains a dedication to the god/goddess through a formula that mentions the king. A temple precinct is a usual habitat for this genre of statuary in Egypt (Schulz 2011). The Sinai block statue was found in such a typical context. It carries the name and the title of the devotee and the name of the target goddess. However, no authority is mentioned in the alphabetic inscription on the block statue. Instead, the text reflects a direct personal attitude to the gods (see below). If the reading of Albright is correct, the text defines the role of the block statue as a 'tribute' or 'gift' to the goddess Baʿalat.

A few hundred years later, one of the first inscriptions written in the linear alphabet on a prestige item in Canaan — the thirteenth-century Lachish ewer — also identifies the ewer as *šy* 'a tribute' from a certain *Mtn* to the goddess Elat (Naveh 1987: 33).

### *Materiality: The Miniature Sphinx Sinai 345*

From an artistic point of view, the little sphinx is a better specimen than the crudely made block statue. As far as it is preserved today, it is a finalised artefact.

45 Dorothea Arnold: personal communication, August 2014.

46 Cf. Brandl 2015: fig. 13, also a small-sized statuette, 25 cm in height. See another example in Bothmer 1960: fig. 15.

47 'Egyptianness' or 'Egyptianicity' is 'the condensed essence of everything that could be Egyptian'; see Goldwasser 1995: 58, n. 7. Compare 'Italianicity' (Barthes 1977: 47–48).

48 Another block statue discovered in Serabit (Schulz 1992: 515–516; Sinai II: fig. 16; Sass 2004/5: 157), made of sandstone, is much more Egyptian in appearance. Clearly dating from the New Kingdom (as evident from its style and from the language of the inscription), it is of poor workmanship. Block statues of various sizes were highly popular throughout the history of ancient Egypt, in all social strata, since their advent in the Middle Kingdom (Schulz 2012).

The lion's tail stands out in its excellent making, very similar to the tails of famous royal sphinxes of the Twelfth Dynasty.[49] The Sinai miniature is a royal female sphinx not too far in its general style from the schist sphinx of the Middle Kingdom princess Ita discovered in Qatna, Syria. It is difficult to know why this specific female sphinx appears in the Sinai desert and if it was ordered on purpose. Maybe a female sphinx was more fitting in the devotee's mind as a gift to the goddess Hathor-Baʿalat. In the Qatna sphinx, the names of Ita and her titles appear on the front part between the sphinx's paws.[50] The front part of the Sinai sphinx is now lost. When used by the Canaanites (in a secondary use?) the object functioned as a gift to the goddess, as the alphabetic inscription on the proper left side reads [?. . .]*lbʿlt* 'For Baʿalat'.[51]

***Materiality: The Sinai 347 and 347a Busts***

The better-preserved bust, Sinai 347 (figs. 18a, 20a), seems unfinished. It shows the head of a man with an Egyptian hairstyle of the Middle Kingdom. Like the block statue, it is executed in the 'local' style and displays a low level of 'Egyptianness'. The head of the second bust (Sinai 347a, fig. 18b) is slightly different, as its ears are much larger than those of the better-preserved bust 347.[52] While the artefacts Sinai 345 and 346 follow easily identifiable Egyptian prototypes — a block statue and a sphinx — the two small figurines are identified in the literature only as 'busts'. I would like to suggest that they are 'spirits' and/or an early provincial version of the Egyptian 'ancestor busts'.

No similar busts to Sinai 347 and 347a have been found in Egypt. However, busts are known from a few Middle Kingdom paintings; the most famous example coming from the tomb of a princess of the Eleventh Dynasty.[53] A bust (fig. 20b) showing a high level of 'Egyptianness' was discovered recently in Tell Edfu. It was found in a 'house shrine' dated by Nadine Moeller to the beginning of the Eighteenth Dynasty (or even earlier). This Egyptian uninscribed bust is only slightly bigger than the Sinai busts, measuring about 20 cm in height. The Edfu bust also represents a non-royal human and is the earliest concrete example known in Egypt to date. All busts share the non-royal attributes and the body's reduction into an unmarked conic basis that is stable enough to serve as a stand allowing the

49 See Fay 1996, esp. fig. 5.

50 For a detailed analysis of the sphinx from Qatna, see Fay 1996: 30–32.

51 Compare Wilson-Wright 2013, who suggests reading an Egyptian loanword *wḏ*, 'stele'.

52 The exaggerated ears are a common feature during in this period, e.g., Brandl 2015: figs. 1–13.

53 E.g., a relief from the tomb of Meketre, Assasif, dated to the Twelfth Dynasty, at the Metropolitan Museum of Art (31.3.183). See also in Wilkinson and Hill 1983: no. 48.105.29, and another coffin in Willems 1996: 73, with fig. 22, 1 and 2. For further material, see Keith 2011. I am grateful to Marsha Hill for her advice on this topic.

Fig. 20. a) Sinai 347 (private photo by the author; see also above, fig. 18a); b) bust found at the Tell Edfu excavation (https://phys.org/news/2019-01-ancient-urban-villa-shrine-ancestor.html, photo courtesy of Nadine Moeller)

small figure to stay upright, perhaps wearing a kind of robe. In Egyptology, these are sometimes called 'ancestors' busts'.[54] They belong to the religious sphere, yet they show no divine attributes.[55] As noted above, the Sinai 347 and 347a busts represent a man with a typical Middle Kingdom hairdo.[56]

What was the meaning of these figurines in the eyes of their Canaanite users? One could cautiously suggest that the Canaanites who placed them in the shrine of Hathor considered them as some sort of 'ancestors' figures', later probably known in the bible as Teraphim.[57] These figures are small and portable, and are

54 For Egyptian 'ancestor busts', see Stevens 2009; Keith 2011; Harrington 2013.

55 Friedman 1985: 97 suggests that 'The busts do not depict recognizable persons; they are free-standing portable 'determinatives' for *ꜣḫ ỉḳr*; presumably, they could be transported from house to tomb or chapel'.

56 For this typical Middle Egyptian hairdo, see examples in Bothmer 1960; Brandl 2015.

57 Van der Toorn (2002: 55, with n. 43) already offers a possible comparison between Teraphim and 'somewhat similar anthropoid busts' in Egypt. For an unlikely suggestion to identify the Teraphim with Egyptian Ushabti figures, see Flynn 2012. However, the Ushabti has a quite different role in the Egyptian culture, as well as a very different form. See also Edelman 2017.

not representations of any specific god; they belong to the sphere of personal religion.[58] Beck (1990) has suggested identifying numerous small figurines found in the Levant from the third millennium onwards as belonging to ancestor worship. Small figurines such as Sinai 347 and 347a could be easily hidden in a saddlebag, as evoked by the biblical story of Rachel who so hid her father's Teraphim (Gen. 31:34). In his discussion of the elusive ancestors' figurines in the Levant, Van der Toorn (1990; 2002) suggests flexible use in houses and as offerings in temples. Howard-Carter (1970) collected such figurines from all over the Levant; all of them are small, with an average height of 20–25 cm. In her opinion, these 'guardian spirits' were at home in temples, houses, and ancestor shrines.[59] Thus the unique little busts from Sinai could stand at the crossroad of the Canaanite cult of dead ancestors and household spirits and the Egyptian ancestors' cult, well suited to the cultural melting pot in Serabit.

### *Agency and 'Canaanite Use' of the Egyptian Objects*

How did the Canaanites perceive the small votive objects, and did they acknowledge their Egyptian use?

Following the Egyptian usage, the block statue Sinai 346 represents its owner in the three-dimensional pictorial, referring to his name and title, and functions as a tribute to the divine. The royal sphinx had been designed as a gift, but kingship might be alluded to by the undecipherable Serekh in the front, legitimizing the inscription. The two little busts might have served as ancestor figurines and as gifts (*tnt*).[60] However, by the contents of their alphabetic inscriptions, the Canaanites and the objects transgress Egyptian decorum of the god/man relationship. As part of the royal control of the Egyptians' lives and beliefs, an Egyptian private person had, officially (= in inscriptions), no direct access to the gods during the Middle Kingdom. The king was the necessary intermediary in any appeal; Vernus (1996) has defined and analysed this Egyptian religious phenomenon (see also Baines 2009: 12–15; Grajetki 2015: 130, no. 64). Rare exceptions may occur on the fringe of the Egyptian-controlled universe, i.e., Sinai, desert areas, or the Levant.[61] In a graffito in Rod el-Air, far from the eye of the official Egyptian administration of the temple in Serabit, dated to the Middle Kingdom, a certain Egyptian servant dares to call himself *mry Hwt-Hr* 'beloved of Hathor'.[62] A Late

58 For the multi-purpose use of the Teraphim, see Van der Toorn 1990.
59 Cited in Beck 1990: 94.
60 'The meaning of an object' is born when that object is used towards a purpose by a group; see Tilley 2001.
61 See Černý in Sinai II: p. 40.
62 Sinai I: pl. XCII, no. 507; Goldwasser 2006: 127, fig. 7b. In this inscription, the humble producer not only calls himself 'beloved of Hathor' but also does not keep the honorific transposition rules of the hieroglyphic script. The bird that is within the *ḥwt* looks more like a duck than a falcon. Compare here the Buhen rock inscription,

Middle Kingdom scarab discovered in Sidon presents a short Egyptian inscription bearing a personal name with the attribute *mry Seth (=Bʿl) nb Ꜣ͗Ꜣii* 'The beloved of Seth/Baʿal, the lord of *Ꜣ͗Ꜣii*'.[63] Only in foreign lands could a non-royal person officiate a scarab with the title 'the beloved of god X'.

The Canaanite texts, written on the miniature sphinx and the block statue, worship the goddess in the 'Canaanite attitude' which allowed a direct personal appeal to the gods. In her detailed study of popular religion in Canaan and the Levant in the Middle Bronze Age, Schroer (1989) identified in the pictorial a 'Canaanite goddess' with unified features of Hathor and Canaanite goddesses. Of an uncertain name, this 'mixed' goddess was a prominent figure in the Volksreligion of the Middle Bronze Age Levant. The 'nude goddess' that is popular in the Canaanite pictorial repertoire presented by Schroer fits the nude clay votive offerings also known in Egypt already by the Middle Kingdom (Pinch 1993: pl. 1). The nude version of the Egyptian goddess had no access to the official religion of Hathor.[64] If Bietak's architectural analysis of the Hathor shrine area in Sinai is correct, an earlier shrine for a local Canaanite goddess might have pre-dated the Egyptian shrines in Serabit (Bietak 2021). It is possible that the Canaanites still retained the cultural memory of this shrine and believed the Hathor shrine to be the abode of Baʿalat.

In summary, the alphabetic inscriptions imbued the four Egyptian statuettes with additional Canaanite agency power. In these inscriptions, anybody, even the unprivileged, could turn directly to the goddess, without intermediaries. In the block statue 346, a direct line was opened between one *Nʿm*, a chief miner in Sinai, and his goddess Baʿalat. This 'personal piety' attitude, i.e., the direct appeal to the gods, would emerge openly in Egyptian texts only during the New Kingdom.[65] This new attitude to one's god could have been another result of the continuing cultural interference process between carriers of Canaanite cultures and Egyptians. This process received a substantial boost during the Second Intermediate Period and many of its after-effects surfaced during the Eighteenth Dynasty and even later.

---

in Baines 1983: 24–26 and Vernus 1996: 842. In Buhen, in a graffito from the Second Intermediate Period, a certain man presents himself as the 'beloved of Isis and Horus'.

63 For a discussion of this scarab and its meaning for the syncretism Seth/Baʿal during the Middle Kingdom, see Goldwasser 2006: 123 and for its publication, see Loffet 2006. The place name *Ꜣ͗Ꜣii* takes the foreign lands classifier.

64 Interestingly, the representation of Hathor as a cow was not popular neither at Serabit, nor on the scarabs from Canaan. Possibly this image did not coincide with that of the Canaanite goddess.

65 Based on his scarab studies, Othmar Keel suggested many years ago that 'personal piety' was a result of Canaanite influence on the Egyptian culture. For a recent contribution on 'personal piety' in Egypt and a survey of the literature, see Bussmann 2017.

## REFERENCES

Albright, W.F.
1969 *The Proto-Sinaitic Inscriptions and Their Decipherment* (2nd printing with additional note), Cambridge, MA

Baines, J.
1983 Greatest God or Category of Gods? *Gottinger Miszellen Gottingen* 67: 13–28
2009 The Stelae of Amenisonbe from Abydos and Middle Kingdom Display of Personal Religion, in Magee, D., Bourriau, J. and Quirke, S., *Sitting beside Lepsius: Studies in Honour of Jaromir Malek at the Griffith Institute*, Leuven: 1–22

Barthes, R.
1977 *The Rhetoric of the Image*, London

Beck, P.
1990 A Note on the ‘Schematic Statues’ from the Stelae Temple at Hazor, *Tel Aviv* 17: 91–95

Beck, P. and Na’aman, N.
2002 *Imagery and Representation: Studies in the Art and Iconography of Ancient Palestine: Collected Articles* 3, Tel Aviv: 288–290

Bietak, M.
2021 Did the Temple of Serabit el-Khadem Originate from an Earlier Canaanite Shrine? in Tristant, Y. and Buchez, N. (eds.), *Égypte Antérieure. Mélanges de préhistoire et d’archéologie offerts à Béatrix Midant-Reynes par ses étudiants, collègues et amis*, Leuven: 59–80

Bothmer, B.V.
1960 Block Statues of the Egyptian Middle Kingdom: II. The Sculpture of Tata’s Son, *The Brooklyn Museum Annual* 2: 18–35

Bourriau, J.
1996 Observations on the Pottery from Serabit el-Khadim (Zone Sud), *Cahier de recherches de l’institut de papyrologie et d’Egyptologie de Lille* 18: 19–32

Brandl, H.
2015 Late Middle Kingdom or Late Period? Re-Considering the ‘Realistic’ Statue Head, in Miniaci, G. and Grajetzki, W. (eds.), *The World of Middle Kingdom Egypt (2000–1550 BC)*, 1, London: 43–56

Bussmann, R.
2017 Personal Piety: An Archaeological Response. in Miniaci, G., Betro, M.C. and Quirke, S., *Company Images: Modelling the Imaginary World of Middle Kingdom Egypt (2000–1500 BC): Proceedings of the International Conference of the EPOCHs Project held 18th–20th September 2014 at UCL, London*, Leuven: 71–91

Butin, R.F.
1932 The Serabit Expedition of 1930: IV. The Protosinaitic Inscriptions, *Harvard Theological Review* 25: 130–203

Carnarvon, G.E.S.M.H., Griffith, F.L., Spiegelberg, W., Newberry, P.E., Carter, H., Möller, G. and Legrain, G.A.
1912 *Five Years' Explorations at Thebes: A Record of Work Done 1907–1911*, Oxford

Chehab, M.
1969 Noms de personnalités égyptiennes découvertes au Liban, *Bulletin du Musée du Beyrouth* 22: 1–47

Cross, F.M.
1989 The Invention and Development of the Alphabet, in Senner, W.M. (ed.), *The Origins of Writing*, Lincoln — London: 77–90

el-Damaty, M.M.
1990 Squatting Statues in the Cairo Museum, *Mitteilungen des Deutschen Archäologischen Instituts*, *Abteilung Kairo* 46: 1–13

Darnell, J.C., Dobbs-Allsopp, F.W., Lundberg, M.J., McCarter, P.K., Zuckerman, B. and Manassa, C.
2005 *Two Early Alphabetic Inscriptions from the Wadi el-Hôl: New Evidence for the Origin of the Alphabet from the Western Desert of Egypt*, Boston

Edelman, D.
2017 Adjusting Social Memory in the Hebrew Bible: The Teraphim, in Jonker, L., Kotzé, G. and Maier, C.M., *Congress Volume Stellenbosch*, Leiden: 115–142

Fay, B.
1996 *The Louvre Sphinx and Royal Sculpture from the Reign of Amenemhat II*, Darmstadt

Finkelstein, I. and Sass, B.
2013 The West Semitic Alphabetic Inscriptions, Late Bronze II to Iron IIA: Archeological Context, Distribution and Chronology, *Hebrew Bible and Ancient Israel* 2/2: 149–220

Fischer-Elfert, H.W. and Grimm, A.
2003 Autobiographie und Apotheose, Die Statue des *Zš(š)n Z3-Ḥw.t-Ḥrw* im Staatlichen Museum Ägyptischer Kunst München, *Zeitschrift für Ägyptische Sprache und Altertumskunde* 130: 60–80

Flynn, S.W.
2012 The Teraphim in Light of Mesopotamian and Egyptian Evidence, *The Catholic Biblical Quarterly* 74/4: 694–711

Friedman, F.
1985 On the Meaning of Some Anthropoid Busts from Deir el-Medina, *The Journal of Egyptian Archaeology* 71/1: 82–97

Gardiner, A.H.
1916 The Egyptian Origin of the Semitic Alphabet, *Journal of Egyptian Archaeology* 3: 1–16
1961 Once Again the Proto-Sinaitic Inscriptions, *Journal of Egyptian Archaeology* 48: 45–48

Giveon, R.
1978 *The Impact of Egypt on Canaan: Iconographical and Related Studies*, Freiburg

Goldwasser, O.
1991 An Egyptian Scribe from Lachish and the Hieratic Tradition of the Hebrew Kingdom, *Tel Aviv* 18: 248–253
1995 *From Icon to Metaphor: Studies in the Semiotics of the Hieroglyphs* (No. 142), Fribourg
2006 Canaanites Reading Hieroglyphs, Part I: Horus Is Hathor? Part II: The Invention of the Alphabet in Sinai, *Ägypten und Levante/Egypt and the Levant* 16: 121–160
2010 How the Alphabet Was Born from Hieroglyphs, *Biblical Archaeology Review* 36/2: 40–53
2011 The Advantage of Cultural Periphery: The Invention of the Alphabet in Sinai (circa 1840 B.C.E.), in Sela-Sheffy, R. and Toury, G., *Culture Contacts and the Making of Cultures: Papers in Homage to Itamar Even-Zohar*, Tel Aviv, 251–316, http://www.tau.ac.il/tarbut/Publications/IEZ-Homage
2012 The Miners that Invented the Alphabet: A Response to Christopher Rollston, *Journal of Ancient Egyptian Interconnections* 4/3: 9–22, https://journals.uair.arizona.edu/index.php/jaei/article/view/16085
2013 Out of the Mists of the Alphabet: Redrawing the ‘Brother of the Ruler of Retenu’, *Ägypten und Levante/Egypt and the Levant* 22: 349–370
2015 The Invention of the Alphabet: On ‘Lost Papyri’ and the ‘Egyptian Alphabet’, in Rico, C., *How Did the Alphabet Come About*?, Newcastle-upon-Tyne
2016a From Iconic to Linear — The Egyptian Scribes of Lachish and the Modification of the Early Alphabet in the Late Bronze Age, in Finkelstein, I., Robin, C. and Römer, T. (eds.), *Alphabets, Texts and Artefacts in the Ancient Near East, Studies presented to Benjamin Sass*, Paris: 118–161
2016b A Paleographic Analysis of the Alphabetic Inscription on Block-Statuette 346 from Serabit el-Khadem to the Alphabetic Inscriptions of the Mines, *Eretz Israel* 32: 21–32 (Hebrew), 115*–116* (English summary)
2018 The Alphabet as a Case of Disruptive Innovation: Egyptian Hieroglyphs as an ‘Old Technology’, the Ugaritic Alphabet as Unsuccessful ‘Improvement’, and some Emoji (Lecture delivered at Rencontre Assyriologique Internationale 64 in Innsbruck, Austria, July 16–18, https://www.academia.edu/38206095

2021 The New ‘Dalet Ostracon’ from Lachish: On the Crossroad of the Early Alphabet and Hieratic Scripts: Paleographic Remarks, https://www.academia.edu/49307111

Grajetki, W.
2015 The Pharaoh’s Subjects, Courts and Provinces, in Oppenheim, A., Arnold, D., Arnold, D. and Yamamoto, K. (eds.), *Ancient Egypt Transformed: The Middle Kingdom* (Metropolitan Museum of Art), New York: 120–159

Grimme, H.
1923 *Althebräische Inschriften vom Sinai*, Hannover

Hamilton, G.J.
2006 *The Origins of the West Semitic Alphabet in Egyptian Scripts*, Washington, D.C.

Harrington, N.
2013 *Living with the Dead: Ancestor Worship and Mortuary Ritual in Ancient Egypt*, Oxford

Hayes, W.C.
1955 *A Papyrus of the Late Middle Kingdom in the Brooklyn Museum*, New York

Hoch, J.E.
1994 *Semitic Words in Egyptian Texts of the New Kingdom and Third Intermediate Period*, Princeton

Howard-Carter, T.
1970 The Stone Spirits, *Expedition* 12/3: 22

Keith, J.L.
2011 *Anthropoid Busts of Deir el Medineh and Other Sites and Collections*, Cairo

Kopetzky, K. and Bietak, M.
2016 A Seal Impression of the Green Jasper Workshop from Tell el-Dabʿa, *Ägypten und Levante/Egypt and the Levant* 26: 357–375

Lehmann, R.G.
2021 Much Ado about an Implement! The Phoenicianising of Early Alphabetic, in Boyes, P.J. and Steele, P.M. (eds.), *Understanding Relations between Scripts* II, *Early Alphabets*, Oxford: 69–90

Lemaire, A.
2008 The Spread of Alphabetic Scripts (c. 1700—500 BCE), *Diogenes* 55/2: 45–58

Loffet, H.C.
2006 The Sidon Scaraboid s/3487, *Archaeology & History in Lebanon* 24: 78–84

Matthiae, P., Pinnock, F. and Scandone Matthiae, G.
1995 *Ebla: Alle origini della civiltà urbana*, Milan

Miniaci, G.
2017 Unbroken Stories: Middle Kingdom Faience Figurines in Their Archaeological Context, in Miniaci, G., Betro, M. and Quirke, S., *Company of Images: Modelling the Imaginary World of Middle Kingdom Egypt (2000–1500 BC)*, Leuven: 235–284
2018 Deposit F (Nos. 15121–15567) in the Obelisk Temple at Byblos, *Ägypten und Levante/Egypt and the Levant* 28: 379–408

Morenz, L.D.
2009 Der Türkis und seine Herrin Die Schöpfung einer besonderen Expeditionsreligion im Mittleren Reich, *Studien zur Altägyptischen Kultur* 38: 195–209
2011 *Die Genese der Alphabetschrift: ein Markstein ägyptisch-Kanaanäischer Kulturkontakte*, Würzburg

Naveh, J.
1973 Word Division in West Semitic Writing, *Israel Exploration Journal* 23: 206–208
1987 *Early History of the Alphabet: An Introduction to West Semitic Epigraphy and Palaeography*, Jerusalem

Petrie, W.M.F.
1906 *Researches in Sinai*, London

Pinch, G.
1993 *Votive Offerings to Hathor*, Oxford

Puech, E.
2002 Notes sur quatre inscriptions protosinaïtiques, *Revue Biblique* 109: 5–39

Rainey, A.F.
1975 Notes on Some Proto-Sinaitic Inscriptions, *Israel Exploration Journal* 25: 107–116

Sanders, S.
2009 *The Invention of Hebrew*, Urbana

Sass, B.
1988 *The Genesis of the Alphabet and Its Development in the Second Millennium B.C.*, Wiesbaden
2004/5 The Genesis of the Alphabet and Its Development in the Second Millennium B.C. — Twenty Years Later, De Kêmi à Birît, *Nâri* 2: 147–166
2008 Wadi el-Hôl and the Alphabet, in Roche, C., *D'Ougarit à Jérusalem. Recueil d'études épigraphiques et archéologiques offert à Pierre Bordreuil*, Paris: 193–203

Sass, B., Garfinkel, Y., Hasel, M.G. and Klingbeil, M.G.
2015 The Lachish Jar Sherd: An Early Alphabetic Inscription Discovered in 2014, *Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research* 374: 233–245

Scandone Matthiae, G.
2004 Les scarabées d'Ebla, in Bietak, M. and Czerny, E., *Scarabs of the Second Millennium BC from Egypt, Nubia, Crete and the Levant: Chronological and Historical Implications. Papers of a Symposium, Vienna, 10th–13th of January*, Vienna: 195–202

Schneider, T.
1992 *Asiatische Personennamen in aegyptischen Quellen des Neuen Reiches*, Fribourg

Schroer, S.
1989 Die Göttin auf den Stempelsiegeln aus Palästina/Israel, in Keel, O., Keel-Leu, H. and Schroer, S., *Studien zu den Stempelsiegeln aus Palästina*, Fribourg: 89–207

Schulz, R.
1992 *Die Entwicklung und Bedeutung des kuboiden Statuentypus: Eine Untersuchung zu den sogenannten 'Würfelhockern'*, Hildesheim: 33–34
2011 Block Statue, in Wendrich, W. (ed.), *UCLA Encyclopedia of Egyptology*, Los Angeles, https://escholarship.org/uc/item/3f23c0q9

Seipel, W.
2003 (ed.), *Der Turmbau zu Babel: Ursprung und Vielfalt von Sprache und Schrift* IIIB, Vienna — Milan

Sinai I Gardiner, A.H., Peet, T.E. and Černý, J., *The Inscriptions of Sinai*, I: *Introduction and Plates*, London, 1952
Sinai II Gardiner, A.H., Peet, T.E. and Černý, J., *The Inscriptions of Sinai*, II: *Translations and Commentary*, London, 1955

Steiner, R.C.
2016 Phonemic Spelling and *Scriptio Continua* for Sandhi Phenomena and Glottal Stop Deletion: Proto-Sinaitic vs. Hebrew, *Journal of Near Eastern Studies* 75: 311–334

Stevens, A.
2009 Domestic Religious Practices. in Wendrich, W. and Dieleman, J. (eds.), *UCLA Encyclopedia of Egyptology*, Los Angeles, https://escholarship.org/content/qt7s07628w/qt7s07628w.pdf

Tallet, P.
2018 *La zone minière pharaonique du Sud Sinaï* III, Cairo

Tilley, C.
2001 Ethnography and Material Culture, in Atkinson, P. *et al*. (eds.), *Handbook of Ethnography*, London: 258–272

Valbelle, D. and Bonnet, C.
1996 *Le sanctuaire d'Hathor maîtresse de la turquoise*, Paris

Van der Toorn, K.
1990 The Nature of the Biblical Teraphim in the Light of the Cuneiform Evidence, *The Catholic Biblical Quarterly* 52/2: 203–222
2002 Israelite Figurines. A View from the Texts, in Gittlen, B.M., *Sacred Time, Sacred Place*, Winona Lake: 45–62

Verbovsek, A.
2007 Befund oder Spekulation? Der Standort privater Statuen in Tempeln des Alten und Mittleren Reiches, in Haring, B. and Klug, A., *Ägyptologische Tempeltagung: Function und Gebrauch lägyptischer Tempelraeme,* Wiesbaden: 257–276

Vernus, P.
1996 Réfections et adaptations de l'idéologie monarchique à la Deuxième Période Intermédiaire: La stèle d'Antefle-victorieux, in Der Manuelian, P., *Studies in Honor of William Kelly Simpson*, 2, Boston: 829–842

Wilkinson, C. and Hill, M.
1983 *Egyptian Wall Paintings*, New York

Willems, H.
1996 *The Coffin of Heqata (Cairo JdE 36418): A Case Study of Egyptian Funerary Culture of the Early Middle Kingdom* (Vol. 70), Leuven

Wilson-Wright, A.M.
2013 Interpreting the Sinaitic Inscriptions: A New Reading of Sinai 345, *Hebrew Bible and Ancient Israel* 2: 136–148
2016 Sinai 357: A Northwest Semitic Votive Inscription to Teššob, *Journal of American Oriental Society*, 136/2: 247–263

Wimmer, S.
2008 *Palästinisches Hieratisch: die Zahl-und Sonderzeichen in der althebräischen Schrift*, Wiesbaden

Yardeni, A.
1983 *Adventures*, Jerusalem (Hebrew)

Zinn, K.
2018 Literacy in Pharaonic Egypt: Orality and Literacy between Agency and Memory, in Kolb, A., *Literacy in Ancient Everyday Life*, Berlin — Boston: 67–97